over 63 per cent of the state's 130 million population. The party is fielding 23 candidates, of whom nine are Yadav, two Muslim, and three Kushwaha leaders. Some 25 per cent of the candidates are women, Lalu's two daughters among them.

The NDA Numbers

For the BJP, Bihar is key to its "*char sau paar*" battle cry. The state has been a fertile ground, delivering 31 and 39 seats (out of 40) to the NDA in the past two LS elections. The return of Nitish and his JD(U) should come as a welcome boost, but there's no denying who is the top dog in the alliance now. For the first time, the BJP is contesting 17 seats, one more than the JD(U)'s 16. The alliance has three other parties—Chirag Paswan's Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas), which gets five seats, Jitan Ram Manjhi's Hindustani Awam Morcha (HAM) and Upendra Kushwaha's Rashtriya Lok Samta Party (RLSP), with one each.

But though the NDA may appear to have the upper hand, it won't be smooth sailing. Nitish's flip-flops between the *mahagathbandhan* and the NDA are finally taking a toll, as is his image as *sushasan babu* (man of good governance). So, while his traditional Luv-Kush (Kurmi-Kushwaha) and EBC vote banks may stand by him, Nitish perhaps needs the BJP more than the other way around.

The CM's conspicuous absence from Modi's rallies in Gaya and Purnia in mid-April also fuelled speculation about a possible rift in the alliance since he had been a fixture at the earlier rallies in Bihar. He did finally make it to the Munger rally on April 26, sharing the stage with the PM as they rallied support for Lalan Singh, but the rumour mills are still active. Meanwhile, it's still not clear how the NDA will leverage Chirag Paswan's Scheduled Caste (SC) votes, particularly the six per cent Paswan voters. The JD(U) and LJP have a history of acrimony and it's anybody's guess how the vote transfer will unfold.

THRUST AREAS

BJP

- Keep Narendra Modi's larger-than-life image at the forefront
- Leverage Modi ki Guarantees, and schemes like free foodgrains and farmers' benefits
- Utilise Ram temple issue, India's rising global stature

Janata Dal (United)

- Use Nitish Kumar's influence over EBCs, Kurmi and Kushwaha voters
- Rely on Modi magic to ensure transfer of BJP votes to JD(U)
- Highlight Nitish's good governance image, Lalu's 'jungle raj'

RJD

- Capitalise on Tejashwi's image as the one who generated employment
- Focus on the 21 % electorate who are youths, promise of 10 million jobs
- Besides M-Y vote bank, focus on other backward communities

The Modi Show

"*Modiji ko Jai Shri Ram*", the giant speakers belt out as the fervent crowd gathered at Munger's Safiabad ground on April 26 responds resoundingly. Women inside the barricaded front rows clutch BJP flags and wave cutouts of the prime minister in a show of unwavering support. The roar grows louder as Modi takes the stage. The shift in the crowd's response, from the muted enthusiasm during Nitish's address, leaves little doubt as to who the star of the show is.

In Bihar, it's Modi who will bring in the votes for the NDA. The alliance is pinning its hopes on the forward castes, a few EBC cohorts and Nitish's Luv-Kush combine to take them across the finish line. Allies Chirag and Manjhi are expected to deliver the Dalit votes.

The larger NDA plan is to fall back on a longstanding social divide in Bihar—the belief that, wary of Yadav dominance, sections of the populace will still refrain from supporting the RJD. Moreover, the Congress is an albatross weighing Tejashwi down. To keep things in context, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has addressed just one public meeting in Bihar so far, in Bhagalpur on April 20. Compared to the BJP's galaxy of star campaigners, that's a poor show.

Conversations with a diverse array of voters in Bihar underscore the enduring significance of Modi and the Ram temple. The NDA is also banking on a sizeable portion of the beneficiaries from welfare schemes like the distribution of five kilos of free grains and crop assistance to farmers.

The NDA and the *mahagathbandhan* have both crafted competing narratives. The low voter turnout in the first two phases—attributed both to the scorching sun and general listlessness of the public—has made it difficult for even experts to predict the results. While the NDA touts Modi's decisive leadership, the Grand Alliance spotlights unemployment and rural distress. The outcome hinges on which narrative resonates most with voters. ■